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HAVE YOU INVITED A MADRAS MALI TO YOUR GARDEN?

On International Women's Day, a conversation with Madras Malis, who are underprivileged women trained in organic gardening practices by a unique empowerment programme **P4**



A 'BALLERINA' SHOWS UP AT NEMMELI SALT PANS

This is the first sighting of the Demoiselle Crane anywhere in the Chennai Metropolitan Area. Naman Bora and Amogh Chetty found the vagrant bird feeding in the reeds at the salterns on February 28 **P2**



Kelambakkam-Covelong Link Road. PHOTO: PRINCE FREDERICK

Danger lurks not just on the bends

Metal barricade medians have been grouted into the bends along the section of Kelambakkam-Covelong Link Road that traces the Kelambakkam backwaters; a couple of wider straights also need this protective measure

PRINCE FREDERICK

Parade before your mind's eye roads that seem to have been "carefully crafted" for head-on collisions? That might sound morbid, but on certain roads, at least certain sections of them, that thought cannot be avoided; motorists moving in opposite directions seem to be charging at each other.

In the heart of the city, motorists might find that unsavoury thought sneaking in on them, while navigating certain sections of Kamarajar Salai (Beach Road hugging the Marina), particularly while Father Time has entered the liminal zone between late evening and early night.

Anyone accustomed to taking the Kelambakkam-Covelong Link Road would find themselves thinking along the same lines while navigating the section of the road that traces the Kelambakkam backwaters and its adjacent patches.

This section of the link road is hugely narrow but that does not deter motorists from speeding. A majority of road users hitting the

link road having no business to transact on this section of the road (exceptions include those in the fish-and-crab catching business, staff at the ICAR-CIBA Kovalam Experimental Station, and anglers and birders and other Nature enthusiasts without a clear-cut agenda). Adding to the risk, this section sports some bends. To alleviate the danger arising from the road's design, short medians of metal barricades have now been grouted into the road at these high-risk bends, making sure vehicular traffic moving in one direction does not spill over into the path of the other. This is just what the doctor ordered for preventing head-on collisions. But the traffic planners have failed to turn over the prescription sheet and read the additional instruction the doctor has scrawled on the other side. The helpfulness of having these grouted metal medians in the slightly wider straights as well to blunt the natural deadly edge this road possesses. Accidents are equally likely, if not more so, on the slightly wider straights, where motorists can let their guard down, unlike while they are on then bends.

Signature campaign by Adyar bus commuters

Adyar residents who rely on MTC's services for commuting and managing their workaday travels recently launched a signature campaign.

The objective of the exercise was to bring to the attention of MTC officials the fact that those "waiting for buses at the bus stop under the Adyar Bridge (which is called Adyar Bridge Bus Stop) have to do without seating arrangements.

The letter with a roll of signatures that was handed over to the manager of the Adyar bus depot noted that this state of affairs "causes great inconvenience to senior citizens, women and other passengers who have to stand for long periods while waiting for buses".

The letter ends seeking provision of "benches for the benefit of the commuters at the earliest."

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This is the first sighting of the Demoiselle Crane anywhere in the Chennai Metropolitan Area. Naman Bora and Amogh Chatty found the vagrant bird feeding in the reeds at the salterns on February 28

A 'ballerina' shows up at Nemmeli Salt Pans



A vagrant Demoiselle Crane at Nemmeli Salt Pans photographed by Naman Bora on March 1 and (below) by Amogh Chatty on February 28.

mented sighting of the bird in Chennai.

Gnanaskandan Kesavabharathi, a senior reviewer at eBird, confirms it and places this individual bird in its life stage based on its features: "It is a sub-adult bird considering the white near throat and forehead, short white ear tufts and the brownish orange iris versus a reddish iris in full adults."

That this bird is a lone vagrant and no "relative" was keeping lock-step with its peregrinations into uncharted territory was confirmed the following morning. Naman observes that on Sunday morning (March 1) he went with wildlife photographer Sudharshan Kuselan to the Nemmeli salt pans and the duo found the Demoiselle Crane around the same spot. Naman displayed greater tenacity, returning to the spot for another two days (March 2 and 3) and found the bird matching his tenacity. Naman observes that the bird was tenaciously clinging on to its feeding spot in the reeds, being found within 100 metres of the spot it was first seen at. "After roosting, it would return to this feeding spot," Naman adds.

Gnanaskandan notes two earlier records of Demoiselle Crane sighting for Tamil Nadu exist. Both have come from Vijaynarayanam Tank in Tirunelveli: two birds sighted in 2006, and one in 2007.

Weighing in on this sighting at Nemmeli, ornithologist V. Shantaram places it in perspective: "A majority of Demoiselle Crane sightings are from western India, specifically Gujarat and Rajasthan. At Khichan Village in Rajasthan, sighting a flock of 4,000-5,000 Demoiselle Cranes is not uncommon. Those are the places they normally visit, but they do move around. These birds are great wanderers. I mean they come from Central Asia and fly down to Gujarat and for them to come down south is not a big thing, but they do not have to unless there is a drought or there is some other reason for their movement. It could be one of those reasons, or just that some of the birds are more adventurous. There are a lot of possibilities; they probably come in here regularly in small numbers (during winter) and we have missed them out."

On the Demoiselle Crane's forays into the south, Shantaram points out there are "records near Bangalore and around Mysore; in Tirunelveli; and "in northern Karnataka, it seems to be fairly regular". On habitats the Demoiselle Crane is drawn to, Shantaram says: "They are found near waterbodies, but they feed in the fields where different kinds of crops are grown. They also feed in the open areas around tank shores that are drier."

PRINCE FREDERICK

Marie Antoinette's image has been shaped by words not her own, but consistently put in her mouth through the centuries. Two things she did not say continue to be misattributed to her. One, the suggestion that the poor French peasants could have cakes if they lacked bread. And the other, oddly, has to do with ornithology. She is believed to have given Demoiselle Crane its name impressed by its uber-feminine movements, largely dance-like. Anyone in India faintly familiar with French having taken it up to bump up the aggregate in their higher secondary board exams, as this writer did decades ago, would realise Demoiselle is from French and a variant of Mademoiselle, denoting a young lady. Back to Marie and her putative bird-christening abilities, this bird was given that name for its ultra-feminine demeanour but not by her. Here is why.

The infamous French queen was born in 1755, and an account of why the bird goes under the name Demoiselle Crane is found, with an illustration, in George Edwards's *A Natural History of Uncommon Birds*, its various volumes written between 1743 and 1751. Even if the account about the Demoiselle Crane spilt out of the quilt-pen in 1751, it is a good four years before Marie arrived. The book is in the



public domain, accessible at Biodiversity Heritage library (biodiversitylibrary.org).

The truth in fact runs deeper, the bird's name and its significance preceding the book.

Why harp on Marie Antoinette and the Demoiselle Crane now? Here is answering this question

nagging the reader. On the evening of February 28, 2026, two youngsters from Chennai were treated to a ballet performance by the "made-moiselle" at the Nemmeli salt pans. Naman Bora, a sophomore-student at VIT on Kelambakkam-Vandalur High Road and Amogh Chatty, a Class X student of PSSBB Millenni-

um at Semmancherry, both members of Madras Naturalists Society (MNS) sighted and photographed a lone vagrant Demoiselle Crane (*Grus virgo*) while it was feeding among the reeds and while it was in flight.

The record of the sighting is up on eBird; and it is the first docu-



Opening careers in Data Science for government school students

Forty Class XII students from 10 government schools recently cleared a certification programme offered by IIT-Madras in association with LatentView Analytics, a Taramani-based company

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

Forty Class XII students from 10 government schools in Chennai have become literates in Data Science and Artificial Intelligence. A two-month certification pro-

gramme under the IIT Madras 'School Connect' initiative validated them after they completed a rigorous weekend curriculum for three months, and all 40 students scored above 80 percent in the final examination.

To celebrate this achievement,

LatentView Analytics, a global data analytics company with office in Taramani, invited the students to the office for a certificate distribution event, where they also got to interact with analytics professionals and explore real-world AI applications.



At the LatentView office; and an employee conducts a session for students of Class XI at Jaigopal Garodia Govt. Girls Higher Secondary School, Choolaimedu.

Under Project Apoorva, a CSR initiative of LatentView Analytics for the last three years, students of classes IX to XII from Chennai's government schools have been learning about Artificial Intelligence and Data Science.

The company works with Learning Links Foundation, an NGO, to provide tutors in the schools to teach students selected by the school foundational data concepts and real world applications, spoken English proficiency, digital literacy, apart from conducting exam readiness workshops and higher education counselling, said a release.

Project Apoorva currently supports 4,121 students across 10 government schools in Chennai through 100 plus structured modules aligned with the academic calendar, said the release.

The schools covered include Jaigopal Garodia Government Girls Higher Secondary School in Saidapet, Government Madrasa-I-Azam in Thousand Lights, Chennai Girls Higher Secondary School in Perambur and Government Higher Secondary School in Nandanam.

The IIT-Madras backed curriculum was a big boost for these students as they got a chance to understand these emerging fields through structured training and mentorship from industry professionals. LatentView Analytics, which sponsored the students, is happy that this exposure to an emerging field gave the students a glimpse of what it is to be future analysts.

Likewise, 40 Class XI students completed an industry-style analytics mentorship programme offered by employees of the company.

On February 4, these Class XI students presented full-fledged data analytics projects at Chennai Higher Secondary School in Ayanavaram, working with raw datasets, conducting cleaning and visualization, and presenting insights before a LatentView evaluation panel, added the release.



The spot in question

'Garbage dumping in eco-sensitive spot behind Perumbakkam Bus Depot'

ANANTA CHARAN SWAIN

An stretch of eco-sensitive marshland behind the Perumbakkam MTC bus depot and the rear side of the gated community Casagrand First City in Cheran Nagar in Perumbakkam has turned into an unofficial dumping yard, raising serious environmental and public health concerns among residents.

Heaps of mixed waste (plastic covers, food waste, discarded clothes and construction debris, to name a few) lie scattered

across the marshy terrain. What was once part of a natural wetland ecosystem now resembles dumping ground.

Residents allege that waste is being dumped regularly, ignoring the area's ecological significance. The marshland, which plays a crucial role in groundwater recharge and flood mitigation, is now choked with non-biodegradable waste. Plastic litter can be seen floating in pools of water.

The proximity of residential complexes, schools, and public

infrastructure makes the issue more pressing. With open dumping comes the risk of foul odour, mosquito breeding, fire hazards, and groundwater contamination.

Residents of Perumbakkam have called for immediate intervention from civic authorities.

They demand strict monitoring, installation of surveillance cameras, fencing of the vulnerable stretch, and regular clearance of accumulated waste.

(Ananta Charan Swain is a resident of Casagrand First City in Cheran Nagar)

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Have you invited a **Madras Mali** to your garden?

They grow gardens in other people's backyards but the blooms extend into their living rooms. On International Women's Day, a conversation with Madras Malis, who are underprivileged women trained in organic gardening practices by a unique empowerment programme designed by Chennai Resilience Centre



SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Many had spent years as homemakers with little opportunity for paid work. Today, as part of the Madras Malis initiative, they travel across neighbourhoods helping households establish and maintain organic kitchen gardens.

The programme traces its roots to the Chennai Resilience Centre's Chennai Urban Farming Initiative, launched in 2021 to promote organic edible gardening in urban spaces. The idea was simple: encourage residents to grow food at home, both as a source of nutrition and as a way to create greener, climate-resilient neighbourhoods where plants help reduce urban heat. Workshops and training sessions were organised with residents, teachers and community groups across the city. But as participation grew, organisers began noticing a recurring challenge. While many residents were eager to start kitchen gardens, sustaining them required technical knowledge most did not possess.

"Residents often told us that even after attending workshops, maintaining a garden was still difficult," says Ayesha Ajmal, Junior Re-

search Associate and Communications Manager at the Chennai Resilience Centre, who coordinates Mali assignments, manages social media, and assists with training sessions. "There were challenges with pests, soil health and identifying the right inputs to use."

Organisers also recognised another gap. While gardeners were available in the city, most focused on routine tasks such as watering or pruning. Few had the expertise to maintain edible gardens using organic techniques or diagnose plant health problems.

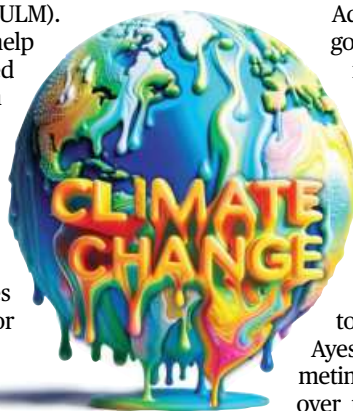
To address this, while also creating livelihood opportunities, the initiative began collaborating with the Tamil Nadu Urban Livelihoods Mission (TNULM). Women from self-help groups were invited to participate in specialised gardening training. This effort gradually evolved into the Madras Mali programme. Ayesha underlines that eligibility for participating in the training

programme is predicated on a woman's membership in a self-help group registered under TNULM.

Between 2022 and 2024, the initiative operated as a pilot under the Urban Thottam project, experimenting with training formats while connecting trained women with households seeking help. By 2025, the programme was formally structured and launched under the name Madras Mali, with a dedicated website, social media presence and a defined list of services. Since 2023, nearly 250 women have received training. The training is designed in stages. Participants begin with fundamentals – soil preparation, plant varieties and common pests.

Advanced sessions go deeper into pruning, identifying fungal infections and diagnosing nutrient deficiencies. "These sessions are usually conducted in modules lasting around two to three hours,"

Ayesha explains. "Sometimes they take place over two or three days



M. Krishnaveni (wearing a hat) from Chintadripet talks to a client about a plant; V. Prabha from R.A. Puram and B. Geetha from Taramani, also at work in their respective client's garden. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

their confidence. B. Geetha from Taramani says the work has given her a sense of financial independence. "Earlier, I depended on my husband even for small things. If my children asked for a pencil or a book, I had to ask him for money. Now I can manage these small expenses myself." Appreciation from residents keeps her motivated too. "Residents sometimes send photos of the harvest. Seeing that makes me feel very satisfied." Others say the programme has expanded their world beyond their immediate neighbourhoods.

V. Prabha from R.A. Puram, who has been working as a Mali for three years, says the experience has made her more confident. "Earlier I hardly stepped outside my area. Now I know some bus routes and I can interact with more people." Gardening has also become a passion. "I keep encouraging people around me to grow more plants at home."

Their work has extended beyond private homes to schools and community institutions, including a Greater Chennai Corporation High School at Kamaraj Avenue in Adyar, the Bala Mandir Kamaraj Trust in Teynampet, Little Flower Nursery and Primary School in Adambakkam and Government Higher Secondary School in Sholinganallur. Students are often involved in sowing and harvesting, turning gardens into learning spaces, with vegetables sometimes used in the institutions' kitchens. "Seeing them eat the greens they harvest for lunch feels more fulfilling than the money," says one of the Madras Malis, M. Krishnaveni from Chintadripet.

The challenges

Like many livelihood initiatives, the programme comes with challenges. Working through Chennai's summers can be gruelling, and the work occasionally involves physically demanding tasks such as carrying heavy pots. Managing client expectations has also required attention; organisers now address this by clearly explaining the scope of work to both parties before assignments begin.

Despite these challenges, the initiative continues to grow largely through word of mouth. Many clients who first hear about the service through friends or neighbours eventually become repeat users. Those interested in availing the Madras Mali service can contact the team via WhatsApp at 9176588007. More details are available at urbanthottam.com/madras-mali-veg-garden-kit/ and @urbanthottam on Instagram.



depending on the women's availability."

Beyond classroom sessions, participants are also exposed to organic farming at scale. In late 2023, a group attended a residential programme at a farm run by the Centre for Indian Knowledge Systems near Vedanthangal, where they explored traditional vegetable varieties, visited rice fields and participated in organic farming demonstrations.

The programme also emphasises entrepreneurial skills. Participants learn to prepare organic pesticides and plant growth promoters using locally available ingredients, which they can market to clients. They are also trained to set up composting systems and guide households in converting kitchen waste into compost. For the Malis, minimum payment is fixed at ₹850 for five hours; the Malis receive the payment directly from the clients and Chennai Resilience Centre does not receive a commission.

A confidence boost

For many participants, the most visible transformation has been in

A dedicated group for women on Radial Road

Federation of Radial Road Residents' Associations (FORRRRA) celebrated its first Women's Day on March 1 called 'Radial Women Rising', bringing together women from gated communities along the arterial Pallavaram-Thoraipakkam 200 Feet Radial Road.

The celebration witnessed the participation of more than 150 women, with over 60 enthusiastically taking part in various cultural and interactive programmes. The event featured programmes such as a Pattimandram, dance and singing and the inspiring 'Bold You' walk, which encouraged women to express confidence and solidarity, said a press release.

The initiative also led to the formation of a dedicated WhatsApp group to help women on Radial Road stay connected beyond the event. "A new WhatsApp group was formed for all of us. This group has become a space for us to stay connected, share ideas, support one another and exchange opportunities. This way we have kept the conversation going beyond Women's Day celebrations and we will ensure this network grows stronger every day," said B. Vijayalakshmi, founder-president of the Federation of Radial Road Residents' Associations, in the press release.



From the event.

Celebrating their strength, resilience



The ninth edition of Realistic Awards was held recently in the city. A social initiative by Pakwan Chennai, SPICA Modular Solutions Limited, Realistic Awards honours women who lead, inspire and redefine excellence in their respective fields.

This year, 20 women from diverse fields were recognised for their passion, perseverance and groundbreaking contributions.

They are Rachitha Mahalakshmi (small screen), Shriniidhi, a radio jockey, Anitha Guha, classical dancer, Lavanya, classical singer, Rakshita Suresh, playback singer, Vagu Mazan, independent artist, Akshatha Das, video jockey, G Kavya, choreog-

rapher, Meenu Balaji, a nutritionist and dietician, Dr Vasundra Thiagarajan, doctor, Salomi Rinita, a make-up artist, Padmini Ravichandran, journalist, Krithika Subrahmanian, architect, Thanupa Santosh (Human Resources), Urvashi Deshpande, interior designer, Preetha Raghav (global facilitator and leadership catalyst), Suramanjari Elangovan, entrepreneur (Fintech), Malar Vikram, costume designer, and Darsani for sports.

On the occasion, the lifetime achievement award was given to veteran actress Rajyalakshmi, honouring her lasting legacy and decades of contributions to Indian cinema and television, the release added.

Medical screening at college

The District Palliative Care Team of Rotary International District 3233 organised an awareness programme and medical screening camp at St. Joseph's College of Engineering. The event was inaugurated by Rotary District Governor D. Devendran. Dr. Ramesh Babu, District Health Director, and Dr. Vetrivel, Additional Health Director emphasised the integration of palliative services into the broader healthcare system. Over 200 teaching and non-teaching staff underwent health screenings, including mammography tests. The initiative was held in collaboration with the Rotary Club of Chennai Sneham and the Rotary Club of Madras West.

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The Department of Museums is organising an artists camp for women on March 7 and 8 at the Gallery of Contemporary Art in Egmore.

More than 70 women artists from across Tamil Nadu will be participating in this special event, a majority being from Chennai. On

Camp for women artists

March 7, there will be a live painting session and on March 8, the completed artworks will be exhibited at the gallery in celebration of International Women's Day.

The idea behind this camp was

put forward by three Chennai-based artists Sathya N. Prabhu, Charanya Rajesh and Gayathri Balaji. "We initially planned to celebrate International Women's Day with a spot painting event and exhi-

bition. When we approached the museum, we were surprised by the enthusiastic support extended by the Department of Museums" says Charanya. The event will see budding and aspiring artists, some juggling full-time jobs, working on different mediums and networking with each other.

This initiative aims to provide a meaningful platform for showcasing the talent of women artists and promoting art and creativity.

The event encourages women, especially homemakers, to come and see the works and interact with artists to see how this can be taken up as a profession.

A fund raiser for those with special needs



Chettinad-Sarvalokaa Education International School in Kelambakkam recently organised a student-led walkathon, which was conceptualised and led by students of grade VIII.

Held at the Health City

campus, surrounded by lush greenery, the walkathon offered participants an opportunity to support a cause while promoting health and well-being, said a release.

The students raised

funds for Sri Arunodayam Charitable Trust, an organisation that empowers individuals with special needs. The funds raised will contribute to the trust's ongoing work in providing essential care, resources, and oppor-

tunities for those they serve, added the release.

The initiative is part of the service learning project of the students, where they demonstrated leadership, empathy, and a strong sense of purpose, the release added.



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